

Presented by:

Hitolo Garia

Registrar | NCD Small Crafts Registration Board



REGISTRAR'S REPORT

Submitted to Board for Board Meeting No.1 of 2025

OCTOBER 13, 2025

NCD SMALL CRAFTS REGISTRATION BOARD

Level 1 City Hall Annex Building, Waigani



NCD SMALL CRAFT REGISTRATION BOARD

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1. Executive Summary

This report provides an operational update on the activities, challenges, and recent developments of the NCD Small Craft Registration Board (NCD SCRB). It highlights progress in registration, enforcement of the *Small Craft Act 2011*, and coordination with enforcement partners. It also identifies key institutional challenges—funding, staffing, and governance and proposes strategies to strengthen small craft safety and compliance across NCD waters.

2. Overview

The NCD Small Craft Registration Board (NCD SCRB) acknowledges the leadership of both the former and current Boards, and the continued support from the National Capital District Commission (NCDC) and the Motu Koita Assembly (MKA).

The first-term Board (May 2020–May 2023), chaired by Mr. Ryan Pini, laid the foundation for implementing the *Small Craft Act 2011* in NCD. However, between 2022 and early 2023, progress slowed due to quorum challenges and members' limited availability. This affected decisions on policy, inspection frameworks, and establishing a permanent office at the waterfront.

After the first Board's term expired, Mr. Pini continued to act in leadership capacity to maintain operations, while the Registrar continued field coordination and registration.

The January 10, 2024 "Black Thursday" looting incident created instability that spilled into maritime operations. Opportunists used small crafts for piracy and armed robbery at Port Moresby's anchorage. PNG Ports Corporation, together with the Water Police, enforced port and maritime security laws to restore confidence and safety. This effort realigned focus on enforcing the *Small Craft Act*, placing pressure on compliance among local operators.

With limited policy and funding capacity, Acting Chair Mr. Pini authorized Theodist Limited in September 2024 to print 600 registration stickers on credit, allowing the rollout of free registration in October 2024. The cost (K30,000) was settled after NCDC released delayed funds in December 2024.

Through 2024–2025, the Registrar continued engagement with PNG Ports, NMSA, and TSSP, and participated in Port Safety & Security Stakeholder Workshops in July 2024 and June 2025. These engagements helped strengthen multi-agency collaboration across the maritime enforcement network.

The second-term Board was sworn in June 2025. Before formal correspondence was issued, **NMSA Legal Division provided written email confirmation authorizing the Board to commence meetings** under Section 3 and 4 of the *Small Craft Act 2011*.

Board Composition (2025–2028):



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- Mr. Ryan Pini – Chair (Private Sector)
- Mr. Nicholas Constantino – Member (Private Sector)
- Mr. Udu Vai – Member (NCDC Representative)
- Mr. Mari Kila – Member (MKA Representative)
- Mr. Neil Papenfus – Member (PNG Ports, Statutory Representative)
- Ms. Megan Taureka Andrew – Member (Private Sector)
- Mr. Aaron Batts – Member (Royal Papua Yacht Club Representative)
- Mr. Paul Gaudi – Member (Motu Koita Community Representative)
- Mr. Nou Vada – Member (Proxy to Mr. Mari Kila; Legal Counsel, Nova Lawyers)

3. Current Issues

3.1 Enforcement and Compliance Pressure

The Water Police's enforcement drive under the *Small Craft Act* has improved compliance but created friction with subsistence fishermen, many of whom depend on dinghies for livelihood.

3.2 Reports of Rogue Conduct

Reports from Motu Koita communities describe instances of:

- Confiscation of fishing catches and equipment
- Spot fines exceeding K500 without receipts
- Intimidation during patrols

The Registrar raised these issues with the Water Police to ensure enforcement is lawful, fair, and sensitive to community livelihoods.

3.3 Private Sector Engagement – RPYC Awareness Session

The **Royal Papua Yacht Club (RPYC)** hosted a Small Craft Awareness Session facilitated by NCD Small Craft Registration Board, and NMSA Legal Team and the Small Craft Officer on **14 October 2025**. The awareness was mainly attended by Small Crafts (Boat/Dinghy) Owners/Operators and members of RPYC.

Key matters raised included:

- Jet ski registration and licensing;
- Recognition of Queensland Marine Licenses;
- Skipper certification and commercial vessel classification; and
- RPYC registration arrangements before 31 December 2025.



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The Registrar advised that these matters will be tabled for Board deliberation, with policy guidance to follow before year-end.

3.4 Operational Limitations

The lack of a patrol boat and waterfront base limits the Registry's ability to conduct inspections and verify enforcement activities. Collaboration with the Water Police for joint patrols is now progressing under an **MOU framework** to be finalized before year-end.

4. Key Challenges

- **Governance:** Quorum challenges between 2022–2023 delayed major policy and program decisions. The Board must ensure regular meetings and consider **appointing proxies** for members frequently unavailable.
- **Funding:** Inconsistent NCDC releases between 2022–2024 constrained operations.
- **Office Space:** The **Koki Fish Market** remains the preferred operational base; Board support is sought to formally engage NCDC and Hon. Justin Tkatchenko (MP).
- **Mobility:** Lack of patrol vessel; partnership with Water Police to provide interim logistics.
- **Policy:** Absence of an approved **Infringement/Penalty/Charges/Fines Policy** remains a critical gap.

5. Way Forward

5.1 Community-Based Inspection Mechanism (Concept Proposal)

The Board will pursue a **combined Small Craft Act Awareness and Inspector Training Workshop**, tentatively scheduled for **2 – 5 December 2025** at the Crowne Plaza Hotel.

Before the workshop, each MKA Councillor will **identify two to three (2–3) community representatives** from their respective wards or electorates, guided by a **selection criteria** to be jointly developed and issued by NCD SCRB and NMSA. These pre-selected representatives will attend the workshop alongside the Councillors, ensuring joint learning on policy awareness, vessel inspection, and basic compliance requirements.

This concept remains **in its proposal stage** and is aimed at establishing a grass-roots inspection and compliance model within MKA communities. While the Registrar has proposed that allowances or logistical support for inspectors could be considered through MKA's internal structures, **this remains a suggestion only** and will be subject to further deliberation and approval by the MKA leadership.

Once refined and endorsed, the initiative will proceed with NMSA's support to formally assess and certify the inspectors before they assume any inspection duties.



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Process: Inspection → Certificate of Compliance → Registration Approval

5.2 MOU: NCDC–MKA Institutional Partnership

A proposed MOU between NCDC and MKA seeks to institutionalize shared oversight, resource allocation, and accountability under the *Small Craft Act 2011*. The objective is to align government policy with community implementation and reinforce collaboration across all stakeholders.

5.3 Joint Patrol Collaboration (Meeting Outcomes and Way Forward)

On **Friday, 10 October 2025**, myself (Registrar) and Chairman **Ryan** met with **Mr. Glenn Finnis**, Executive Director of the **RPNGC Water Police Directorate**, and **Mr. Giwi Yaku**, Assistant Director Operations.

Discussions focused on:

- Development of a **Working Memorandum of Understanding (MOU)** between the Water Police Directorate and the NCD Small Craft Registry;
- **Current registration issues** (new, renewals, and transfers) and coordination challenges at the provincial level; and
- **Opportunities** to streamline information-sharing and conduct joint enforcement operations.

The Registrar also raised ongoing concerns about the **mistreatment of fishermen** by some officers. The Water Police leadership acknowledged these matters and committed to addressing discipline and oversight.

Mr. Finnis confirmed that the **draft MOU** is being prepared and will be shared for review. Once finalized, it will serve as the foundation for **joint patrols, enforcement logistics, and data coordination** between both institutions.

6. Financials

The financial position as of **9 October 2025** remains stable. The 2025 operational grant was released in April.

Annex A: Financial Report 2025 provides details of receipts and expenditures to date.

A **balance of K309,000** remains, earmarked for:

1. Combined SCA Awareness & Inspector Training Workshop
2. Procurement of Patrol Boat (for deliberation)
3. Operator ID Card Machine (PVC type)



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4. Mobile Registration App Development
5. Office furniture and computers

2026 Budget Forecast

Divided into three parts:

- **Part 1 – Operations Budget:** Administrative and logistical operations, including waterfront office setup.
- **Part 2 – Programmes Budget:** Awareness drives, inspector certification, digital upgrades.
- **Part 3 – Structure / Remuneration Budget:** Staffing and payroll framework for 2026–2028.

Supporting Annexes:

- Annex B – 2025 Budget Summary
- Annex C – 2026 Budget Forecast
- Annex D – Remuneration Costings (Direct, On-Costs, Summary)

7. Staffing & Structure (2026 Readiness and Continuity)

Since its establishment in 2020, the NCD Small Craft Registration Board (NCD SCRB) has operated under the Motu Koita Assembly (MKA) payroll structure. Currently, the Registry is managed by the Registrar, who oversees all administrative, operational, and enforcement coordination functions, supported by Admin Support Officer Mr. Andy Frank.

The Registry continues to engage Inspectors on an as-needed basis, primarily during awareness and registration drives. While this arrangement has enabled the program to stay functional, it remains unsustainable without permanent funding and formal staffing provisions.

The MKA's new organizational structure has already been submitted to the Department of Personnel Management (DPM) for Salaries and Conditions Monitoring Committee (SCMC) approval. Once endorsed, the current MKA structure—and by extension, the Registrar and Admin Support Officer's positions—will cease to exist under MKA's payroll. This could occur before the end of 2025 or early 2026, presenting a serious continuity risk for the Registry's operations.



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7.1 Immediate Priority — NCDC Funding for Continuity

The Board must urgently secure **direct and increased NCDC funding** in the 2026 fiscal year to safeguard continuity and transition the Registry into a fully functional office with adequate support.

7.2 Medium-Term Institutionalisation via SCMC

Once the NCDC provides interim funding and the Registry stabilises, the Board can then pursue SCMC endorsement to formalise the structure under NCDC's administrative system, ensuring long-term job security, salary grading, and proper reporting lines.

7.3 Decisions Sought

1. Approve the 2025 and 2026 budget
2. Endorse the preparation of a formal funding submission to NCDC for staffing and office establishment/Operations;

Summary:

The NCD Small Craft Registry currently operates on minimal manpower and temporary support. Securing NCDC funding in 2026 is critical to maintaining operations, protecting existing staff, and transitioning the Registry from an ad-hoc setup to a professional, permanent maritime institution.

9. Conclusion

The NCD Small Craft Registration Board has shown exceptional resilience through years of financial and institutional uncertainty. The establishment of the second-term Board has restored stability and momentum, paving the way for sustained progress under the renewed leadership of **Chairman Mr. Ryan Pini**.

With the Registrar and Admin Support Officer carrying the full administrative and operational load - and Inspectors engaged only when funding permits—the Registry's current model is stretched but still performing. This dedication has kept NCD's small-craft safety framework functioning despite limited resources.

Looking ahead, 2026 will be a decisive year. The Board's priorities must now focus on:

- **Securing full NCDC funding** to support staffing and office establishment;
- **Establishing a permanent base** at the Koki Fish Market to improve service access;
- Finalising the **Penalties/Fines Policy** for consistent, fair enforcement;
- Implementing the **NCDC-MKA-SCRB MOU** to institutionalise coordination and accountability (for deliberation); and



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- Advancing the **Community-Based Inspection & Awareness Program**, empowering MKA councillors and local inspectors to lead compliance at the grassroots level.

Through the continued partnership of **NCDC, MKA, NMSA, PNG Ports, and the Water Police**, the SCRB is poised to evolve from a small administrative office into a fully recognised maritime regulator for the National Capital District.

With proper support and clear direction, 2026 will mark the year that the NCD Small Craft Registration Board transforms from a transitional setup into a **strong, sustainable, and community-driven maritime institution** dedicated to safety, compliance, and the well-being of NCD's coastal communities.

Hitolo Garia

Registrar | NCD Small Craft Registration Board